once wrote: ‘Statements, offers, remarks and suggestions made during the discussion are kept on written records by the Chinese side. Eventually everything that has been said will be weighed and nothing will be forgotten.’ [9]

The Chinese have been known to make references in official talks to ideas that the opposite number may have brought up in informal discussions or even casual conversation, as if these were formal proposals. Therefore, it is preferable to clear the exploratory proposals or ideas with the authorities back home unless there is no time for that, so that the Indian interlocutor is not subsequently embarrassed when the Chinese side raises a proposal made by her or him in official talks and claims that they were given to understand that this was a serious offer. Informal discussions can also be tricky. The Chinese interlocutor will always claim that the ideas being mooted are their ‘personal’ view. This is almost never the case. They also tend to play with the emotions of the opposite side’s interlocutor in smaller, informal gatherings, by suggesting that she or he can frankly speak about the issue. The purpose is to get the Indian interlocutor to be more loquacious in the privacy of an informal setting, so that the Chinese counterpart is able to gauge the Indian interlocutor’s negotiating brief or to press upon her or him to settle on Chinese terms in the interest of early resolution.

It is, therefore, advisable to convey in explicit terms, both at the start of any informal meeting and when it is concluding, that any ideas or proposals that the Indian interlocutor has made, is her or his personal view and cannot be talked about in the official discussions. The Chinese may still make a reference to it, but in that case the Indian interlocutor can state that besides the Chinese interlocutor, his associate and the interpreter were also in the room when the Indian interlocutor